

# THE MORNING KICKOFF

📍 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Tonight: France–England for bronze — tomorrow, the final



📅 Tonight, 23:00 our time: France–England in Miami — Mbappé's last swing at the Boot

★ The Crystal Ball's call: France 2–1 — full workings on page 3

📅 Tomorrow, 21:00: THE FINAL — Spain–Argentina. Kalshi: Spain 43, Tie 32, Argentina 28

🔥 THIRD PLACE · TONIGHT · 23:00 · MIAMI

## BRONZE FOR THEM. GOLD FOR HIM?

Nobody dreams of the third-place match — but tonight's has a trophy hidden inside it. Mbappé sits level with Messi on eight goals, and while Messi must wait for tomorrow's final, Mbappé gets first strike in Miami. Around him, two bruised teams pick through their squads: Saliba is likely out for France, Rice is not expected to start for England, and Kobbie Mainoo may finally get his first World Cup minutes.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- 🔥 Team news: Saliba's first-half injury against Spain likely rules him out — Lacroix is favourite to step in. England may hand debuts and rest Rice, with James also a doubt.
- ★ The Crystal Ball says France 2–1 tonight — and returns tomorrow morning with its final-day call for Spain–Argentina. Record: 5 from 9, two exact scores.
- 📅 Tomorrow at MetLife, 21:00 our time: the final. The money keeps climbing — \$1.66m on Kalshi, split Spain 43, Tie 32, Argentina 28.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 Tonight previewed in full — plus tomorrow's final card and the back catalogue
- P.3 The Crystal Ball: France 2–1 — probabilities, factors, and the live market
- P.4 Golden Boot decision day one: Mbappé strikes first, Messi answers tomorrow
- P.5 The bracket, the last week strip, and one sleep to the final



Kylilan Mbappé — eight goals, one game left, and first swing at the Golden Boot tonight

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)

🇫🇷 France – England

🇬🇧 23:00

🇪🇸 Spain – Argentina

🇦🇷 Sun 21:00

FULL PREVIEWS PAGE 2 →



THIRD PLACE · TONIGHT · MIAMI



France

VS

England



23:00 00:00 +1 02:30 +1 17:00 15:00

Kick-off 5:00 PM ET at the stadium

📍 Hard Rock Stadium, Miami

Two bruised heavyweights and one live prize. France are without Saliba and full of players with a point to prove after the Spain silencing; England weigh how much to rotate, with Rice not expected to start, James a doubt, and Mainoo pushing for a debut. Kane, Bellingham and Saka are all expected to feature — Tuchel does not do dead rubbers. And above it all: Mbappé, level on 8 with Messi, striking first. The market says France, 52 to 25.

- 👁 Every Mbappé touch — one goal tonight and Messi needs to answer in a World Cup final
- 👁 Mainoo's possible first minutes, and how much England's kids change the tempo
- 👁 Dembélé and Olise against a reshuffled England back line — France's fit forwards smell goals



KEY MAN · FRANCE

Kylian Mbappé

Held without a shot on target by Spain, handed one more night by the calendar. The Golden Boot is decided across two evenings — and he bats first.

THE FINAL · TOMORROW · METLIFE



Spain

VS

Argentina



🕒 Sun 21:00

Kick-off 3:00 PM ET at the stadium

📍 MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

One more sleep. Spain's 37-game unbeaten run and record defence against Argentina's 13-game World Cup streak and stoppage-time sorcery. Yamal's hamstring is being managed; Argentina are at full strength. The money has settled: Spain 43, the tie 32, Argentina 28 — \$1.66m and climbing. The Crystal Ball's final call lands tomorrow morning, alongside everything you need for the last day of the tournament.

- 👁 Yamal v Messi — eras collide with the trophy on the table
- 👁 Messi's Boot maths: whatever Mbappé does tonight, the answer comes at MetLife
- 👁 Spain have never trailed this tournament; Argentina have never needed a lead



KEY MAN · SPAIN

Mikel Oyarzabal

Five goals, ice from the spot against France, and the man Spain trust in the biggest moments — as Euro 2024's final scorer already proved.



FRANCE–ENGLAND: THE BACK CATALOGUE

Recent meetings lean French — England still owe them one



England

2 – 0

France



England 66 · group



France

2 – 1

England



Euro 2004 · Zidane's two



France

2 – 1

England



Qatar 22 · Kane's missed pen



France

? – ?

England



Tonight · Miami

TOMORROW: THE FINAL — SPAIN–ARGENTINA, METLIFE, 21:00 CET





France v England



★ OUR CALL: FRANCE 2-1

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO TAKE THE BRONZE



⚡

LIVE MARKET · KALSHI · REGULATION-TIME MONEYLINE · \$1.17M

France 52% 52%

Tie 25% 25%

England 25% 25%

FORM

France were perfect until Spain suffocated them; England were unbeaten until the 92nd minute on Wednesday. The difference: France's front line is fit and furious, England's legs did 120 minutes twice this month.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

The last two tournament meetings both went France's way by 2-1 — Euro 2004 with Zidane's late double, Qatar 2022 with Kane's missed penalty. England's last win in this fixture at a World Cup was 1966.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

Saliba is likely out for France with Lacroix ready; England expect to rest Rice, have a doubt over James, and may debut Mainoo. Rotation cuts both ways — but England's is deeper.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Kalshi's \$1.17m leans hard French: 52 against 25 for England, 25 the draw. Note: a drawn third-place match goes straight to penalties — a quarter of the money expects exactly that.

⚡

THE VERDICT

France 2-1, and Mbappé finally beats a goalkeeper again — third-place games open up, and his four days of frustration need somewhere to go. England score, the kids impress, but the bronze goes to France.

The Crystal Ball is for family bragging rights only. Probabilities blend live prediction-market prices with our own reading of form, fitness and history. Entertainment — not financial or betting advice. Record so far: 5 winners from 9, two exact scorelines.





### Lionel Messi

Bats second — the final answers whatever Miami asks

8



### Kylian Mbappé

Bats first tonight — a goal puts the Boot in Messi's court

8



### Erling Haaland

Eliminated — his race ended one goal short

7



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Messi's assist count means Mbappé likely needs to win it outright with a goal tonight — a tie on 8 probably goes Argentine.

## ⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

52%

France's price on Kalshi tonight — England and the draw sit level on 25

\$1.7m

Already traded on tomorrow's final — the biggest market of the tournament

5

Kane's goals — the 2018 Golden Boot winner needs a miracle three tonight

2022

The last France–England World Cup meeting — 2–1 France, and that missed penalty



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9-12 July · Semi-finals 14-15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · FT · France won 2-0 · · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · FT · Spain won 2-1 · · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · FT · England won 2-1 aet · · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · FT · Argentina won 3-1 aet · · Kansas City

Argentina

Switzerland

SEMI-FINALS

FT · Spain won 2-0 · Dallas  
France 0-2 Spain

FT · Argentina won 2-1 · Atlanta  
England 1-2 Argentina

THE FINAL

**TOMORROW · 21:00 ·**  
**Spain v Argentina**

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Wednesday 15 July — the trophy on Sunday 19 July

**WED**  
**15 Jul**

SF2: England 1-2 Argentina

**THU**  
**16 Jul**

Rest day

**FRI**  
**17 Jul**

Rest day

**SAT**  
**18 Jul**

Third place:  
France-England · 23:00

**SUN**  
**19 Jul**

THE FINAL:  
Spain-Argentina · 21:00

**MON**  
**20 Jul**

The wrap-up special

**TUE**  
**21 Jul**

Football-free mornings resume



See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the bronze verdict, the Spain-Argentina Crystal Ball, and your complete guide to final day.